

NINE-MONTH LIBERATION WAR OF 1971

1971

1952



Presented by ,

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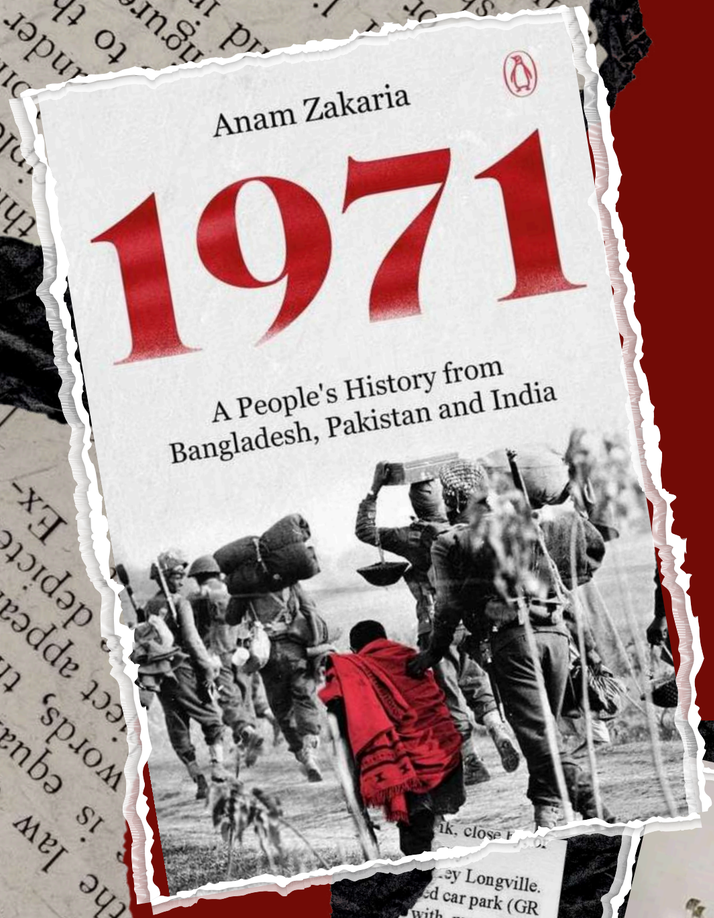




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INTRODUCTION

01.

From 26 March to 16 December 1971, Bangladesh fought a historic struggle for freedom against political denial and military aggression. The war reshaped South Asia and remains one of the most significant liberation movements of the twentieth century.

- Duration: 9 months
- Major outcome: Independence of Bangladesh
- Surrender: 93,000 Pakistani troops (largest since WWII)
- Themes: identity, resistance, collective sacrifice

Sedition of a bloody war

ORIGINS AND KEY EVENTS

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THE LANGUAGE MOVEMENT OF 1952

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GENERAL ELECTION OF 1970

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THE LIBERATION WAR OF 1971

1970

RISING TENSIONS BEFORE 1971

Awami League’s decisive victory in the 1970 election gave Sheikh Mujib the democratic mandate to govern Pakistan. Deliberate refusal to transfer power turned political tension into a national confrontation.



Key Elements

- Awami League: 167/169 seats in East Pakistan; nationwide majority
- Yahya Khan postpones National Assembly twice
- Bhutto's refusal: “Udhar tum, idhar hum” (You rule there, we rule here)
- Non-cooperation movement: paralyzed banks, courts, administration
- 3 million people gather at Race Course Ground for the 7 March Speech
- Armed Bihari–Bengali clashes increase tension
- Pakistan Army secretly prepares for crackdown

OPERATION SEARCHLIGHT (25 MARCH 1971)

The Night That Changed Everything

Operation Searchlight began on the night of 25 March 1971 as a planned military crackdown aimed at silencing Bengali nationalism. Pakistani forces launched coordinated attacks across Dhaka, targeting students, police, civilians and intellectuals. Entire neighborhoods were burned, homes were raided and thousands were killed within hours. This brutal assault marked the beginning of the Liberation War and exposed Pakistan’s determination to crush the Bengali population by force.

TARGETS OF THE CRACKDOWN

Attacks focused on Dhaka University, Rajarbagh Police Lines and Hindu-majority areas, leaving a trail of destruction and mass casualties.

MILITARY COMMAND STRUCTURE

The operation was directed by General Tikka Khan, Rao Farman Ali and Major General Khadim Raja, each responsible for executing the repression.

IMMEDIATE AFTERMATH

Curfews, arrests, disappearances and mass graves emerged across the city, forcing civilians to flee and fueling the nationwide call for independence.

DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE

Despite the violence of 25 March, the Declaration of Independence was proclaimed on 26 March 1971. Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman’s message was relayed from Chittagong and broadcast to the nation. Though Mujib was soon arrested and flown to West Pakistan, his call ignited resistance across towns, districts and villages. The declaration became the moral foundation of the Liberation War.

1971

FORMATION OF THE MUJIBNAGAR GOVERNMENT







LEADERSHIP FRAMEWORK

Syed Nazrul Islam became Acting President, Tajuddin Ahmad served as Prime Minister and General M. A. G. Osmani took command of the freedom forces.

INSTITUTIONAL ORGANIZATION

The government established administrative wings, collected taxes, formed foreign missions and managed relations with India and other supportive nations.

POLITICAL SIGNIFICANCE

It united the global community behind Bangladesh and strengthened the legitimacy of the liberation movement.

10 APRIL

MUKTI BAHINI AND SECTOR COMMANDERS

Formation of Mukti Bahini: The Bangladeshi guerrilla resistance force was formed in 1971 to fight for independence from Pakistan.

Composition: Comprised of defected Bengali soldiers, civilians, students, and volunteers who were trained locally and abroad.

Guerrilla Warfare: Conducted hit-and-run attacks, sabotage, and intelligence operations against Pakistani forces.

Sector System: Bangladesh was divided into 11 sectors, each led by a Sector Commander to organize military operations effectively.

Notable Sector Commanders: Major Ziaur Rahman (Sector 1), Major Khaled Mosharraf (Sector 2), Major ATM Haider (Sector 6), among others.

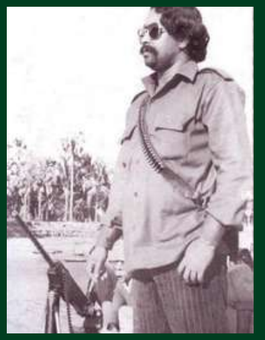
Role in Liberation: Mukti Bahini operations weakened Pakistani control, paving the way for India's intervention and Bangladesh's independence.












GENOCIDE AND HUMANITARIAN CRISIS

The Human Cost of the War

The Liberation War created one of the largest humanitarian disasters in South Asian history. Pakistani forces carried out systematic killings, mass rapes and torture, while targeting intellectuals, Hindus, students and political activists. The violence displaced millions and left deep scars across the nation.

Scale of Atrocities

Approximately three million people are believed to have been killed, and more than two hundred thousand women suffered severe violence.

The Refugee Exodus

Ten million Bengalis fled to India, creating overcrowded camps struggling with disease, food shortages and sanitation crises.

Intellectual Killings

On 14 December, Al-Badr forces abducted and murdered teachers, writers, doctors and journalists in a final attempt to cripple Bangladesh’s future.



MAJOR BATTLES AND OPERATIONS

Turning the Tide of War
Throughout 1971, Mukti Bahini fighters and later allied Indian forces launched a series of strategic operations that weakened Pakistan's control. These battles not only liberated regions but also boosted morale and demonstrated growing military strength.

Key Battles
The Battle of Garibpur showcased early joint success, while the Battles of Boyra, Sylhet and Kamalpur marked major turning points.

Special Operations
Operation Jackpot, led by naval commandos, destroyed Pakistani ships in key ports, disrupting supply lines.

Air and Ground Coordination
Kilo Flight, the first Bangladesh Air Wing, conducted air raids on fuel depots and communication centers.





ROLE OF STUDENTS, WOMEN AND CIVIL SOCIETY

During the Liberation War of 1971, students, women, and civil society played a crucial role in Bangladesh's struggle for independence. Students actively organized protests, strikes, and awareness campaigns, often leading the frontlines in resisting oppression. Women contributed both on and off the battlefield, providing medical aid, shelter, and even participating directly in guerrilla activities, while also enduring immense hardships. Members of civil society—including teachers, journalists, and local leaders—supported the movement by spreading information, coordinating relief, and maintaining morale. Together, these groups created a resilient social backbone that complemented the efforts of the Mukti Bahini, strengthening the overall fight for freedom.

1971



INTERNATIONAL AID & SUPPORT

$10 M

INDIA

10 Million Refugees Sheltered

35+

COUNTRY

Created international voice

GLOBAL AWARENESS

50K TON+

WFP

World Food Program (WFP) → 50,000+ tons of food delivered to camps

BBC & International Press → Broadcasts on atrocities → Global awareness and pressure
Foreign journalists → Reports from refugee camps → Helped mobilize foreign aid

DIPLOMATIC DEFENSE

30,000+

INDIA

Supplied 30,000+ rifles, training camps, and guerrilla support

USSR

Provided tanks, fighter jets, and naval support indirectly aiding Bangladesh

INTERNATIONAL SOLIDARITY

Save the Children → Schools in refugee camps → 500,000+ children educated



INDIA'S ENTRY & JOINT COMMAND

3 December 1971 --India officially entered the war after preemptive Pakistani air strikes

Joint Command --Mukti Bahini + Indian Army coordinated operations under Eastern Command

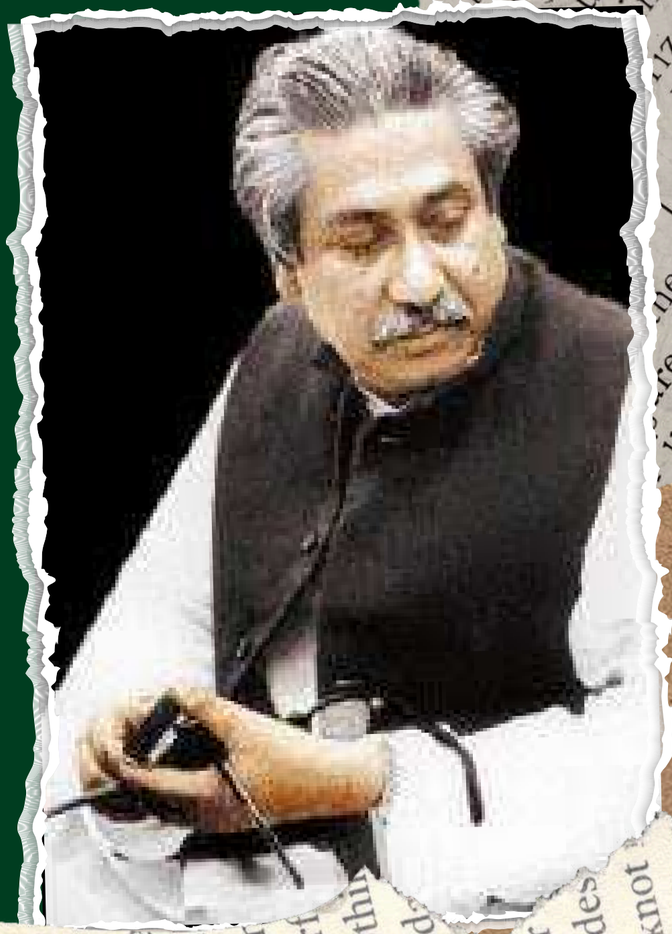
Objective -- Rapid liberation of Dhaka and major strategic regions

DECEMBER OFFENSIVE & SURRENDER

- 7–16 December 1971 → Final Indian-led offensive across East Pakistan
- Pakistani Forces → Cornered in Dhaka, cut off from reinforcements
- 16 December 1971 → Lieutenant General A.A.K. Niazi surrendered to Lt. Gen. Jagjit Singh Aurora
- Result → Formation of independent **Bangladesh, ~93,000 Pakistani troops captured**

AFTERMATH OF THE WAR

Casualties 3 million+ Bangladeshi lives lost; millions displaced
Refugees --Over 10 million returned from India after independence
Destruction--Cities, infrastructure, and industries heavily damaged
Reconstruction-- Indian & international aid helped rebuild hospitals, schools, and roads



LEGACY & CONCLUSION

Independence -Bangladesh officially recognized as a sovereign nation on 16 December 1971
Global Impact - Highlighted human rights violations; inspired international humanitarian interventions
National Identity - Strengthened Bengali language, culture, and sense of nationhood
Military Lessons - Successful joint operations by Mukti Bahini and Indian Army set a model for guerrilla-national army coordination

THANK YOU